



holistic and integrated approach to DM.

Excellence at all levels...

To ensure the spreading out of disaster control measures at all levels, this enabling arrangement was also extended to the grassroot level by setting up of District Disaster Management Authorities (DDMAs) headed by the District Collectors. Notably, the co-chairmen of the DDMAs are the elected representatives of the Zila Parishads, so as to bring about the much needed community - administration interface.

India spends almost two per cent of its gross domestic product (GDP) annually on meeting the cost of relief and rehabilitation in the aftermath of such disasters.

What makes these disaster management measures truly effective is the realization that this sector is no longer the concern of any one ministry anymore. The heads of governments themselves heading the national and state authorities speaks volumes about the firm national resolve to uproot the problem comprehensively, without more ado.

DM: Making tracks

Year 2005 marked the signing of the Hyogo Framework by India and also the enactment of the DM Act 2005, a clear indication of the government's steadfastness to move expeditiously on the path to better management of disasters. Now, the efforts can no more be termed as a mere disaster risk reduction exercise.

- A National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), of 10,000 troops, has been created as a specialised force placed under the superintendence, direction and the administrative control of the NDMA.
- A National Institute of Disaster Management (NIDM) for capacity development has been created to function within the broad principles and guidelines of the NDMA.

- A National Executive Committee (NEC), consisting of 14 secretaries of the concerned ministries and the Chief of Integrated Defence Staff (to coordinate the work of the three defence forces), has been formed at the national level to assist the NDMA. This ensures total synergy at the national level. Also, at the state and district levels, the disaster management authorities will be assisted by the state and district administrative machinery. The subject of disaster management will continue to be on the state list.

What's more, the man-made disasters have also been brought under the umbrella of these institutions besides the management of natural disasters.

A Model Budge in Disaster Management

The strategy for paradigm shift is based on 'six pillars' which include-

Pre-disaster phase

1. Prevention;
2. Mitigation and preparedness measures;
3. Community based disaster management;
4. Operationalization of NDRF and strengthening of NIDM;

Post-disaster phase

5. Response (rescue, relief and rehabilitation);
6. Reconstruction and recovery.

Preventive Measures

Necessity of making the disaster affected community fully aware of the various types of disasters and their impact, and training them in elementary preparedness measures to enable them save their own lives before the organised help arrives, are the key elements of the improved community preparedness. Regular mock exercises are also being carried out by the NDMA for the community and administrative machinery with the help of the states, NDRF, and civil defence besides the NGOs and other stakeholders. The response has been overwhelming and positive.

More than 16 such exercises have been conducted in different states in the last one year. In February 2008, one such exercise was simultaneously conducted by the NDMA at four stations of the Delhi metro. It is planned that as a part of this effort, the states will be geared to conduct such exercises in at least one-fourth of their districts every year, thus ensuring better all-round preparedness.

Mitigation Projects and Preparedness Activities

Certain natural hazards can be prevented from turning into major disasters through mitigation measures. Working on this principle, extensive efforts are being made towards awareness generation and mock exercises, rapid operationalisation of NDRF and further strengthening of NIDM.

All alleviation measures will be mainstreamed into all developmental plans and programmes and this will be ensured by the Planning Commission, central ministries and the states, with the assistance of the NDMA.

Besides, the various national-level mitigation projects being carried out by the NDMA include —

WIND AND CYCLONE ZONES IN INDIA



1. National Cyclone Risk Mitigation Project (NCRMP)

— This project envisions the construction of cyclone shelters away from vulnerable areas, forecasting and early warning arrangements, immediate alarm dissemination measures, shelter belt plantations, improvement of coastal roads in the identified areas for speedy evacuation of affected people and movement of responders. Aided by the World Bank, this project is pegged at Rs 2000 crore. This project will be implemented in 13 cyclone-prone union